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AI Action Plan

National Coordination Office, National Science Foundation
2415 Eisenhower Avenue
Alexandria, VA 22314

Submitted via: [REDACTED]

To Whom it May Concern:

The Assistive Technology Industry Association (ATIA) is a nonprofit 501(c)(6) organization for manufacturers, sellers, and providers of assistive technology (AT)—products, equipment, and systems that enhance learning, working, and daily living for persons with disabilities including school age children eligible under the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act (IDEA). Working as the premier organization serving as the collective voice of the AT industry in the U.S. and abroad, and to help ensure the best products and services are delivered to persons with disabilities, we write to respond to the Office of Science and Technology Policy (OSTP) through National Science Foundation request for input regarding the development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Action Plan (“Plan”) as directed by a Executive Order on January 23, 2025 which directs the development of an AI Plan to advance America's AI leadership.

Our recommendations focus on three areas queried by NSF including research, development, and [K-16] education. They are as follows:

I. Invest in new assistive technology that leverages AI

Artificial Intelligence (AI) has the potential to revolutionize Assistive Technology¹ (AT) in K-16 classrooms and career education, offering transformative improvements in communication, visual aids, mobility, and support for K-16 students with disabilities. New and existing sources of federal research and development funds should be made available -both public and private- to develop new AT models that leverage AI and to support the integration of AI into existing AT products. We already know that when AI is integrated into existing AT (e.g., AI-enabled hearing aids, voice activated personal support, care, or assistance etc.) it helps users of AT maintain all types of daily tasks related to learning, living, and earning. Policy and funding must also encourage innovation in AI that addresses the needs of children, youth, and adults with disabilities. To do so, investments must support cross-disciplinary research and development to drive innovation in AI including in developing AT solutions.

¹ Assistive technology is defined as any piece of equipment, device, or system used to improve or maintain the ability level of the individual with a disability in the educational setting, in employment, in transportation, and in all aspects of daily living. Assistive technology can be handmade, store brought, a modified item, or a specially designed device. See: P.L. 117-328, *The 21st Century Assistive Technology Act* (2022).

II. Invest in accessible AI to ensure human flourishing

As with any new technology development, AI-driven development and implementation platforms must be developed and designed accessible (i.e., they are available to all), must incorporate the principles of universal design², must include accessibility features as a standard (not merely optional), and for federal agency use, all AI-supported technology must also meet the required accessibility standards under Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act of 1973.³ If education and employment-centric AI does not adhere to these essential requirements, our investments will only create barriers which will limit access to education, career training, and economic opportunities for millions of disabled individuals who want to thrive and experience “human flourishing” alongside their peers.

III. Engage stakeholders in AI plans, including people with disabilities

To ensure that AI technologies do not create barriers for people with disabilities, investment [in AI and AI-integrated AT] must foster collaboration and partnerships between AI developers, AT developers and providers, disabled individuals, educators, and other end-users. Individuals with disabilities must be included from the outset of research and development to understand their needs and preferences and gather insights and feedback on AI-driven AT solutions. Much can be gained when researchers, developers and innovators engage the disability community for input and integrate disability awareness within mainstream technology conversations, planning, and implementation.

ATIA appreciates the opportunity to provide recommendations regarding the AI Plan. If we can provide additional information, please contact us at [REDACTED]

Sincerely,

David Dikter
Executive Director

² Universal design is the design and composition of any products or environments are designed to be accessed, used, and understood to the greatest extent possible by all people, regardless of age, size, ability, disability, without the need for adaption or specialized design. See: *The UDL Guidelines* at: <https://udlguidelines.cast.org/>

³ Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act of 1973 is the standard customarily used to consider whether or not environments or materials are compliant with requirements of the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA). See: P.L. 93-112, as amended (29 U.S.C. §794d). See also: the "Guide to Accessible Web Design Development [to implement Section 508]," <https://www.section508.gov/content/guide-accessible-web-design-development/> and the recommendations of the [World Wide Web Consortium \(W3C\)](https://www.w3.org/).